

Afternoon Discoveries

Sunday, September 20, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

SEP 20, 2026



Emerging Writers, Debuts,

& Reading Worth Revisiting

Sunday is where new voices meet the books and pieces that still have something to say. Today begins with a debut novel newly pulled back into view by one of this week's major award announcements, then moves through stories, interviews, and forthcoming first books that make a good case for looking early.

All links were checked against the linked publisher, magazine, author interview, or literary organization page on September 20, 2026.

Featured Discovery

Mad Eden - Morgan Thomas

Morgan Thomas's debut novel follows Ro, a patient navigator at a gender-affirming care nonprofit, through one destabilizing summer in Florida. The book moves through work, partnership, online obsession, and questions of language and time, with an experimental fantasy serial folded into its structure. It was published on June 2, and it returned to the conversation this week as one of the debut novels on the 2026 National Book Award for Fiction longlist. This is a useful place to start if you like literary fiction that lets form participate in the story rather than simply carry it.

[Visit the publisher page for Mad Eden](#)

The Discovery Desk

The Wall Climbers - Amaya Ranatunge

Salt arrives before the sea in the opening of this September story from The Common. Ranatunge begins with the physical atmosphere of Galle Fort and lets place, family, and danger gather around a young narrator whose curiosity keeps pulling her toward the walls. The magazine also provides an audio version, so readers can choose how they enter it.

[Read The Wall Climbers in The Common](#)

The Ninth Island - Andrew Chi Keong Yim

Yim's forthcoming debut poetry collection follows family movement from Hawai'i to Las Vegas and reaches back toward his Chinese American great-grandmother. In this new cover conversation, he explains why an empty pair of car seats could hold the book's ideas of home, absence, imitation, and displacement. The collection is scheduled for publication by the University of Pittsburgh Press on February 9, 2027.

[Read the cover conversation with Andrew Chi Keong Yim](#)

Fallow - Sarah Anderson

In Fallow, a woman accepts a highly paid job as a corporate surrogate and spends nearly a decade discovering what

employment, bodily autonomy, motherhood, and community ask of her. Anderson's conversation with Debutiful is especially good on two difficult craft problems: tracking change in a passive narrator and making isolation carry tension. Her account of accepting that she is neither a daily writer nor a morning writer is also a quietly useful reminder that a workable practice does not need to resemble anyone else's.

[Read the interview about Fallow](#)

Forever Egg - Tierney Oberhammer

This debut collection links twelve stories across centuries, moving from a working-class family trip in 1980 to descendants leaving Earth in 2400. Love, identity, shame, race, and inherited choices recur, but the time span keeps changing the ground beneath them. Modern Artist Press lists the paperback for March 2, 2027, which makes this an early look rather than a review after the conversation has already formed.

[Visit the publisher page for Forever Egg](#)

Beyond this point are more debuts, an award-winning first novel, and older pieces worth returning to.

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Beyond the First Shelf

Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

The Last Stampede - EC Dorgan

EC Dorgan's forthcoming debut brings four Métis characters together in a prairie landscape being consumed by data-centre development. One of its central images is a woman whose broncos emerge from her arms, and Dorgan's cover conversation shows how that image travelled from the manuscript into the final design. House of Anansi is scheduled to publish the novel on April 27, 2027.

[Read the cover conversation with EC Dorgan](#)

The Correspondent - Virginia Evans

Virginia Evans's first novel builds the life of Sybil Van Antwerp through letters and emails - sent, answered, and sometimes withheld. What begins as a sharply observed portrait of an older woman expands into a story about grief, stubbornness, forgiveness, and the people who know different versions of us. The novel won the 2026 PEN/Hemingway Award for Best First Novel, and the publisher page includes a sample and reading guide.

[Visit the publisher page for The Correspondent](#)

Everything I Haven't Done **- Morgan Thomas**

If *Mad Eden* catches your attention, this 2024 story offers a shorter way into Thomas's work. It begins with a housemate, an ex, and vegetables left on a stoop, then draws intimacy out of the odd category between stranger and friend. The clipped exchanges and small domestic transactions do a surprising amount of emotional work.

[Read Everything I Haven't Done in The Paris Review](#)

Side Streams **- Yasmin Adele Majeed**

Majeed's forthcoming debut novel follows family secrets through a Filipino American and Pakistani American family in the Bay Area. In the newly published cover conversation, she discusses a design grounded in local landscape and in the Diego Rivera mural that helped inspire the book. Little, Brown is scheduled to publish *Side Streams* on March 30, 2027.

[Read the Side Streams cover conversation](#)

Awake in the Floating City **- Susanna Kwan**

Kwan's debut imagines a flooded San Francisco through the relationship between Bo, a former art professor, and Mia, a young woman who becomes her caregiver. The premise is

large, but the novel's attention stays close to art, memory, obligation, and the stubborn work of caring for another person. It was a finalist for the 2026 PEN/Hemingway Award for Debut Novel.

[See the PEN/Hemingway finalist page](#)

Special Recommendations

84, Charing Cross Road - Helene Hanff

First published in 1970, Hanff's book collects twenty years of letters between a New York writer and a London bookseller she never meets. It remains a small, funny, unexpectedly moving argument for what can grow out of books passed from one person to another. A new Penguin Classics Deluxe Edition now pairs it with a foreword by Virginia Evans, which makes it an especially fitting companion to *The Correspondent*.

[Visit the publisher page for 84, Charing Cross Road](#)

The Husband Stitch - Carmen Maria Machado

Before *Her Body and Other Parties* appeared in book form, this story revealed the strange, fearless territory Machado was beginning to claim. She reshapes the old green-ribbon tale into an unsettling examination of desire, bodily autonomy, and the

damage caused by a love that refuses to respect a boundary. Return to it for the audacity of its form and the precision with which every warning gathers weight.

[Read The Husband Stitch](#)

A Temporary Matter - Jhumpa Lahiri

Published before *Interpreter of Maladies* introduced Lahiri's work in book form, this quiet story follows a grieving couple who begin exchanging secrets during a series of scheduled power outages. Ordinary domestic details gradually expose everything the pair can no longer say in daylight. It remains a remarkable early example of how restraint can make an emotional turn land with devastating force.

[Read A Temporary Matter](#)

Today's selections show that a debut rarely begins on publication day. It begins in the stories, interviews, private fascinations, and earlier work that teach a writer what a first book needs to become.

Thank you for reading and subscribing. Your support gives this publication the time to look beyond the loudest releases and toward work that might otherwise be missed.

I hope one of today's writers gives you a book to anticipate, a piece to return to, or a reason to follow a new name.

Take care!